

k-th order statistic Index Preservation under Bounded Score Perturbations

Research Architecture Runtime

operator/kth-order-statistic

2026-07-29

Abstract

The kth order statistic operator selects a unique strict k -th order-statistic index. When every pairwise score gap exceeds 2ε , that index is invariant under $\|\delta\|_\infty \leq \varepsilon$. Lean: `LEAN_FULLL` (reduction of `OrderStat.KthMargin`).

This theorem is: Reduction

1 Problem

The `kth-order-statistic` operator on scores $s \in \mathbb{R}^n$ ($n \geq 2$) returns the unique index i that is the strict k -th smallest coordinate of s (operator-specific choice of k). The selected object is this index under a unique strict-order presentation.

2 Stability notion

Perturbations are additive δ with $\|\delta\|_\infty \leq \varepsilon$. Stability: if i is the unique strict k -th smallest and `AllGapsExceed`($s, 2\varepsilon$), then i remains the unique strict k -th smallest of $s + \delta$. Sharpness: a rival within distance 2ε admits an admissible tying adversary.

3 Definitions

Definition 1 (Strict k -th smallest). Index i is strict k -th smallest if $\#\{j : s_j < s_i\} = k$ and $s_j = s_i \Rightarrow j = i$.

Definition 2 (All-gaps). $|s_p - s_q| > g$ for all $p \neq q$.

Assumptions. $n \geq 2$, $\varepsilon \geq 0$, unique strict k -th index, and (for invariance) all pairwise gaps $> 2\varepsilon$.

4 Theorem

Theorem 3 (Invariance). *If i is strict k -th smallest and $\text{AllGapsExceed}(s, 2\varepsilon)$, then for every $\|\delta\|_\infty \leq \varepsilon$, i remains strict k -th smallest for $s + \delta$.*

Theorem 4 (Sharpness). *If some $j \neq i$ has $|s_i - s_j| \leq 2\varepsilon$, an admissible midpoint δ destroys uniqueness.*

5 Intuition

An ℓ_∞ adversary moves any two scores by at most 2ε relative to each other. Gaps larger than 2ε cannot reverse or tie; gaps of size at most 2ε admit a midpoint collision.

6 Examples

Example 5. Scores $(1, 4, 7)$, $k = 1$, $\varepsilon = 1$: gaps $3, 6, 3$ all exceed 2 , so the middle index is stable. For $\varepsilon = 2$, the gap $3 \leq 4$ admits a midpoint tie between the first two coordinates.

7 Proof

Let $s' = s + \delta$ with $\|\delta\|_\infty \leq \varepsilon$.

Pairwise orders. If $s_p < s_q$ and $s_q - s_p > 2\varepsilon$, then $s'_p - s'_q \leq -(s_q - s_p) + 2\varepsilon < 0$, so $s'_p < s'_q$. The converse is symmetric. Hence $s_p < s_q \Leftrightarrow s'_p < s'_q$ whenever $|s_p - s_q| > 2\varepsilon$; under all-gaps this holds for every distinct pair.

Count. Taking $q = i$ yields $\#\{j : s_j < s_i\} = \#\{j : s'_j < s'_i\}$. If the left side equals k , so does the right.

Uniqueness. If $s'_j = s'_i$ and $j \neq i$, all-gaps give $|s_j - s_i| > 2\varepsilon$, hence $s'_j \neq s'_i$, contradiction. Thus i remains the unique strict k -th index (Theorem ??).

Sharpness. For $j \neq i$ with $|s_i - s_j| \leq 2\varepsilon$, set $\delta_i = -(s_i - s_j)/2$, $\delta_j = (s_i - s_j)/2$, and $\delta_t = 0$ otherwise. Then $\|\delta\|_\infty \leq \varepsilon$ and $s'_i = s'_j$, so uniqueness fails (Theorem ??).

8 Formal statement

Lean module

Research.Operators.KthOrderStatistic.Preservation

Source file

`lean/Research/Operators/KthOrderStatistic/Preservation.lean`

Theorems

- `kth\_order\_statistic\_margin\_invariance`
- `kth\_order\_statistic\_margin\_sharpness`

Note

Definitional reduction of `OrderStat.KthMargin`.

Certificate

`lean/certificates/kth-order-statistic/kth-order-statistic-margin`

Status

LEAN_FULL on Mathlib $\mathbb{R}$ (REAL_MATHLIB)

9 Proof dependencies

- Reduces to `Research.Operators.OrderStat.KthMargin`.
- Uses the ℓ_∞ relative-gap bound $|\delta_p - \delta_q| \leq 2\varepsilon$.
- Midpoint collision adversary.
- No other operator theorems required.

10 Consequences

Operators reducing to the same k -th core include `quantile`, `median`, `percentile`, `kth-order-statistic`. The `kth-order-statistic` theorem is the stability certificate for unique strict order-statistic selection under bounded score noise.